

Final Call

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Channel Conflict

An AP works in any of the channels that it is supposed to work in. The RF, say 2.412 GHz for channel 1, represents the centre frequency. Similarly, 2.417 represents channel 2. These channels are separated by 5 MHz from each other. However, the bandwidth that each of these channels needs is around 30 MHz—15MHz on each side of the centre frequency. Hence, technically, two APs overlap each other if they use consecutive channels.

If you assign channel 1 to Access Point 1, then you cannot use channels 2, 3, 4, and 5 for the second Access Point, as 2 and 3 will overlap with 1 while 4 and 5 will overlap with 2 and 3. This means you can only use channel 6. Now, if you wish to connect a third AP, then only channel 11 is available. Channel 11 is the last channel available, so if you wish to connect a fourth AP, you cannot do so without overlap.

change channels, while Linksys' WPC11 does not allow you to save the configuration to the disk.

Price

Linksys' WPC11 provides the best price for an AP at Rs 4,000, while Dax's DX-910AB0 and Net4India's N4I-WB2200APR products turned out to be too expensive.

Thus, even though the top two performers were Net4India's N4I-WB2200APR & Dax's DX-910AB0, pricing made the Linksys WPC11 and the Comex WP11B+ the winners.

Connections Of An AP

The site survey determines the location and nature of an AP needed. Now that you have selected a device to buy, you need to install it. The first step is simply placing the APs at the determined locations and powering them up.

A factor that plays an important role is the type of Internet connection. If you have a cable/DSL connection, you need to connect the cable from the provider to the WAN port of the AP. You need to know details such as the IP address, the subnet mask and the gateway from the ISP provider.

If you access the Internet using dial-up, you need to connect the modem to the USB/COM port. However, if the device you selected has an RJ-11 port, you can just connect the telephone line directly. There is no need for a separate modem, as the device will have an inbuilt modem.

Most of the devices have four LAN ports. If you wish, you can connect up to four machines using wires to the LAN ports.

Minimum Configuration In An AP

To configure the AP, you have to connect at least one PC with a wireless PCI card or a Wi-Fi-enabled laptop to the network of the AP. If you do not have a Wi-Fi-enabled machine, you can connect using a 'patch cord'.

For the LAN—be it wired or wireless—it should have the 'Obtain an IP address' setting enabled. The DHCP server in the AP will assign an IP to a wireless client. In some APs, DHCP is turned 'off', so you will have to look up the manual—to obtain the IP address of the AP, as well as find the other steps you need to take.

To access browser-based configuration, you will need to know the relevant username and password combination. This information is different for each AP, and you will need to refer to the manual to figure out a particular combination.

There are three important tasks that you need to perform as soon as you log in. The first is specifying the ESSID and channel:



Comex WP11B+